



RAVAGED: Illegal mining has eaten away the Barda sanctuary

LOOT IN GANDHI'S LAND

On the outskirts of Porbandar lies the murky, lucrative world of illegal limestone mining. An official investigation reveals the nexus between several big-time politicians and petty operators.

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Porbandar has always shared very little with the ideology of its most illustrious son. The gun, and not Mahatma Gandhi's message of non-violence, has been dominant in this coastal district which boasts of the largest limestone deposits in the country. A massive investigation by the Porbandar district administration and the State Mines and Mineral Department over the past year and a half has revealed that powerful local politicians, goons and petty operators have illegally mined 1.50 crore tonne of limestone worth Rs 500 crore over the past decade in the district. The investigations are going on and the final figure could be higher still.

The main operators in the racket are all big-time politicians—former BJP minister Babu Bokhiria, a local gangster Bhima Dula (he is also the brother of BJP MLA Karsan Dula), his son

Laxman Bhima and former Congress MP Bharat Odedra. The three—Bokhiria, Bhima Dula and Odedra—are closely related to each other. While Bokhiria was arrested on the eve of the recent Gujarat polls and is still in jail, Odedra is out on bail and has been barred by the court from entering the district. Dula is already in jail on an earlier charge of murder. Apart from the trio, there are several small operators in this racket who are brazenly looting limestone from the mines with impunity.

The whole operation came to light in 2006, when the district collector H.N. Chibber and police chief raided a big mine near Porbandar and caught several labourers illicitly excavating limestone. On interrogation it was found that they were working for the trio Bokhiria, Bhima Dula and Odedra. As per the records the mine belongs to

Saurashtra Chemicals, now owned by the Nirma Group, but has never been excavated by the company. The police has charged the trio with theft of limestone worth Rs 56 crore.

Says Arjun Modhwadia, leader of opposition in the state Assembly and Congress MLA from Porbandar, who won the recent poll defeating Odedra's wife and BJP nominee Shantaben,

"Bokhiria and Bhima Dula are the backbone of this racket. They have flourished only due to the patronage they have got from Gandhinagar." Says Devsinh Modhwadia, a local Congress worker and

student leader, "Illicit mining is the source of all unlawful activity in Gandhiji's birth place. If this can be brought under control, it should have an overall positive impact on Porbandar's environment." Both Bokhiria's wife Shantaben and Odedra

